

1 An Introduction to Themeing the Data

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Terminology for and approaches to qualitative data analysis are not standardized. Researchers in the field generally adhere to conventions established by early and contemporary methodologists from quantitative, qualitative, and mixed-methods approaches. These traditional understandings are general since analytic term definitions and methodologies are not fixed but somewhat fluid and signature. This includes the term *theme* and the varieties of *thematic analysis* developed by selected writers.

This chapter first clarifies, from my perspective, several terms applied to qualitative data analysis with a focus on *theme*. I then profile when *themeing the data* is an appropriate approach for a research study, followed by two specific methods and examples of thematic analysis: *categorically* and *phenomenologically*. Additional heuristics for thematic analysis follow, such as analytic memoing, phrasing and composing thematic statements, hierarchical outlining and processual ordering, and a survey of how other researchers have presented themes in their final reports. The chapter concludes with recommended readings in thematic analysis and its methodological cousin, interpretative phenomenological analysis.

Terminology

I first review six key terms and their meanings (as I conceive and implement them) related to analysis: *code*, *pattern*, *category*, *concept*, *assertion*, and *theme*. Though they each possess distinct qualities, their representations can at times overlap. For example, the analytic outcome of a category could also possess the characteristics of a concept; the sentence-length structure of an assertion and a theme are quite comparable. This interchange will be discussed later. For now, I present working understandings specific to this chapter. Some researchers may consider these “old school” constructs out of step with more contemporary approaches to qualitative inquiry, but I am a firm believer in knowing the rules before you can break them.

Choreographer Twyla Tharp famously posited, “Before you can think outside of the box, you have to start with a box.”

Code

A code is a word or short phrase that symbolically assigns a summative, salient, essence-capturing, and/or evocative attribute for a portion of written, oral, or visual data (Saldaña, 2021, p. 5). Coding is an analytic method that condenses units of qualitative data into abridged forms for purposes of pattern detection and development of other analytic outcomes such as categories, concepts, assertions, and themes.

For example, if I were an ethnographer looking at the artifacts and a family’s actions in one particular room of their home, several codes I might use to interpret and catalogue my observations would be FOOD STORAGE, COOKING, REFRIGERATOR, AFTER-SCHOOL SNACKING, and KITCHEN. (I distinguish codes from other analytic representations by setting them in capital letters.)

Pattern

I use the analogy that each room of a house is like a category in which relevant patterns of organization and human action occur. A pattern consists of repetitive, regular, or consistent occurrences of action/data (i.e., codes) that occur more than twice in the data. Thus, the codes FOOD STORAGE, COOKING, REFRIGERATOR, AFTER-SCHOOL SNACKING, and KITCHEN are clustered together by commonality because they “look-alike” and “feel alike” (Lincoln & Guba, 1985, p. 347).

But just as statistics are probabilistic and not deterministic (e.g., distribution, frequency, variance, standard deviation, margin of error), Braun and Clarke (2006), in their oft-cited thematic analysis article, offer a realist perspective that “a pattern in data is rarely, if ever, going to be 100% complete and non-contradicted” (p. 95). If one of the documented actions in the room that exhibits COOKING and AFTER-SCHOOL SNACKING includes GOSSIPING, the seemingly anomalous action of GOSSIPING should not be automatically discounted from the pattern in progress but considered as (1) a separate element of another possible pattern; (2) part of a related yet subordinate pattern; (3) a trigger to reflect on a broader, more inclusive pattern; or (4) an irrelevant observation for answering the primary research question of interest.

Pattern construction is the primary heuristic for generating qualitative data analytic outcomes, and the next four terms serve as representations of that analysis.

Category

A category is a word or short phrase that labels a grouped pattern of codes. This analytic outcome provides further condensation of the data. The codes FOOD STORAGE, COOKING, REFRIGERATOR, AFTER-SCHOOL SNACKING, and KITCHEN could be represented as pattern-derived categories, such as **Food Preparation** or **Kitchen**. Notice that **Kitchen** is both a code and category, for sometimes, a particular code can best represent the assemblage as a category label as well. (I set categories in bold font.)

Concept

A concept, like a category, is also a word or short phrase that symbolically represents a pattern of action/data, but a concept suggests interpretive meanings broader than a single item or action—a “bigger picture” beyond the tangible and apparent. A concept suggests an abstract idea rather than a tangible object or observable behavior. The “sense test” is a heuristic to validate the researcher’s word choices for a concept—if it can be sensorially perceived, it’s not a concept.

A kitchen is something that can literally be observed, but conceptual ideas such as **Gastronomy**, **Family Subsistence**, or **Creative Cookery** cannot. These conceptual words and phrases extend beyond the obvious **Kitchen** category label to evoke broader or even more imaginative ideas. Concepts later become important components of theoretical statements.

Assertion

Frederick Erickson (1986) composed an influential chapter for educational researchers that outlined a holistic yet systematic approach to assertion development from fieldwork observations. An assertion is a sentence-length summative or interpretive claim based on evidentiary adequacy. If any disconfirming evidence or discrepant cases appear that negate the validity of the original assertion, the statement is revised to accommodate the data. The analytic goal is not to look for proof to support assertions but rather to develop plausible, inference-laden observations about the local and particular social world under investigation and their possible implications for broader generalizations.

Coding data beforehand is not always necessary for assertion development, though the method might help analysts become more intimately familiar with each datum. Erickson instead advises multiple readings of the data to gain synoptic awareness of their contents as the analyst’s mind formulates and documents summaries of participant perceptions and interactions. Assertions are arranged in hierarchical outline format according to their

evolving status as assertions and their constituent subassertions, with one overarching statement designated as the key assertion. Overall, the method relies on asking, “After reading and reflecting on the data, what evidence-based impressions summarize what’s going on?”

Using the kitchen as data illustrated thus far, a descriptive assertion of observed action, reaction, and interaction might read, “Moments of ‘family time’ occur in the kitchen.” A more interpretive assertion might offer, “Kitchens are historic sites of memory and legacy where family recipes passed down from previous generations are replicated.”

Theme

Of the six analytic terms discussed in this chapter, theme is (1) the most elusive in definition and meaning, (2) a term conceived differently by several qualitative methodologists, and (3) arguably the most frequent analytic outcome of qualitative studies presented in published journal articles.

I define a theme as an extended phrase or, preferably, a complete sentence that organizes and identifies what a group of repeating ideas in data is about and/or what it means. Some journal article authors label their outcomes as themes when, from my perspective, they would have been better labeled as categories due to their brevity. I offer that researchers think of categories as pages or sections of a news website (e.g., **Politics, Entertainment, Business**) and themes as descriptive news “headlines” for a research report (e.g., “World must protect land to avoid climate disaster,” “COVID-19 casts uncertainty in stock market”). Themeing the data can be conceived facetiously as “coding on steroids.”

When Themeing the Data Is Appropriate

In one of my data analysis manuals (Saldaña, 2021), I strongly caution that *not every qualitative analysis should employ coding*. Comparably, not every qualitative analysis should employ themeing the data. Thematic analysis methodologist Victoria Clarke offered in one of her webinars, “Sometimes your data will tell you how they want to be analyzed.” Thus, thematic statements may be composed as analysis progresses because the researcher inductively determines that extended-length themes will best represent the findings’ complexity. But there are also times when the researcher strategically chooses during the project’s early design stage to represent their forthcoming findings as thematic statements, generated most often through the heuristics of thematic analysis.

Selected qualitative methodologies such as case study, phenomenology, and metasynthesis; disciplines such as health care, sociology, and psychology; plus qualitative research in areas such as teaching, social media, and identity; lend themselves to thematic analysis. Braun and Clarke (2014)

advocate reflexive thematic analysis for *applied* research as “a toolkit for researchers who want to do robust and even sophisticated analyses of qualitative data, but yet focus and present them in a way which is readily accessible to those who aren’t part of academic communities” (p. 2).

Clarke, Braun, and Hayfield (2015) offer that thematic analysis is appropriate for research questions on the following:

- People’s lived experiences about...
- People’s perspectives on...
- Factors and social processes that underpin particular phenomena
- Practices—i.e., the things people do in the world
- Representations of particular subjects, topics, and objects in particular contexts
- Social construction of a particular topic or issue (p. 227)

The co-authors admit that there is no precise formula for the final number of resulting core themes from an analysis, but they recommend a minimum of two and a maximum of six (p. 241). Other published studies, however, include several more, such as ten. Smith, Flowers, and Larkin (2022) recommend that for a theme to be “plausible it must be inhabited by at least half of the participants in the study. However, this is not a hard-and-fast rule” (p. 105).

Thematic Analysis Prompts

“Troubling the data” is a phrase used by selected postmodernists and post-structuralists to examine a data corpus in unconventional ways to critically interrogate its language and embedded meanings. I advise that thematic analysis should instead go “looking for trouble” by investigating the data for participant conflicts in the form of questions and prompts:

- What worries or concerns are the participants expressing?
- What unresolved issues are the participants raising?
- What do the participants find intriguing, surprising, or disturbing (Sunstein and Chiseri-Strater, 2012)?
- What types of tensions, problems, or conflicts are the participants experiencing?
- What kinds of trouble are the participants in?

Bernard, Wutich, and Ryan (2017) also recommend that themes can be found in the data by looking for qualities such as the following:

- Repetition of ideas (i.e., patterns)
- Participant or indigenous terms and categories
- Metaphors and analogies

- Naturally occurring transitions or shifts in topic, linguistic connectors (“because,” “since,” “then,” etc.)
- Missing data
- Theory-related material, such as sociological concepts (pp. 121–122)

Additionally, I have been creatively inspired to construct thematic statements in the following ways:

- “A theme captures a ‘moment’; it tells a story” (Braun & Clarke, 2021, p. 137).
- “A theme is nothing more than a song title” (anecdotal).

Two Themeing Approaches

Just as sentence-length assertions can range from the descriptive to the interpretive, themes can range in structure from the *categorical* to the *phenomenological*. Thus, my own approaches to themeing the data include two distinct analytic forms and methods:

- *Categorical* themes outline and provide descriptive or interpretive detail about the patterns observed and constructed by the analyst.
- *Phenomenological* themes outline what a phenomenon or concept “is” or “means”—the essences and essentials of a particular lived experience.

Though some methodologists advise coding data first in order to discern patterns and then construct themes, I theme the data from the very beginning if I know beforehand that thematic statements will best represent my analytic outcomes. This process adapts Erickson’s (1986) heuristics for assertion development—a process I re-envision as holistically, intuitively, and open-endedly systematic.

Themeing the Data: Categorically

Themeing the Data: Categorically relies on extended phrases or complete sentences to document the patterns observed and constructed by the researcher in order to represent the analytic outcomes thematically. The researcher assigns a categorical theme to each relevant unit of data, then proceeds to assemble the thematic statements into comparable clusters and/or to organize the themes into hierarchical outline formats.

As an example, a central research question for a qualitative health-care study might read: “What is the process of becoming physically disabled?” Social media data chronicles Michael’s (pseudonym) experiences through time. The participant is a single, well-educated, low-income man in his mid-60s,

morbidly obese (380+ pounds), a diabetic with hypertension and chronic kidney disease, clinically depressed, and a prostate cancer survivor. Over the course of six months, Michael slowly at first then rapidly becomes physically disabled, and he publicly posts his status for friends and through private messages to a close friend on Facebook. The following is the beginning of the data corpus with categorical themes (in caps) assigned to the units by the analyst. Notice how a new theme is assigned when the topic within a post changes:

December 11, 2019 [FRIENDS POST]

My back is a bit worse again this evening. Very difficult to sit upright. Sadly, the muscle relaxer is not fully covered by my insurance. ... Keep on praying God will provide!

EXPERIENCING MOBILITY-
AFFECTING PAIN
ASKING FOR PRAYER AND
PROVISION

December 28, 2019 [PRIVATE MESSAGE]

My arms and legs are beginning to feel like jelly. Plus, I'm getting low on the courage, will power, and determination required to get me up on my feet to use the bathroom. Just getting it off my chest. Sometimes it helps just to talk about it.

PHYSICAL PAIN AFFECTS
MOTIVATIONAL AGENCY
DISRUPTION OF DAILY
FUNCTIONS
VENTING TO A FRIEND

December 30, 2019 [FRIENDS POST]

I think maybe I need to call soon for medical assistance. It took me half an hour and a lot of anger and cussing and tears to get up out of bed this time. I just want to lie here. ... I'm getting too shaky and lightheaded to make it to the kitchen. I have a call into the doctor about getting Home Health services, but the staff there is notoriously slow about returning calls. I just want to be able to get up and take care of myself.

DEBILITATING PAIN LEADS
TO EMOTIONAL DISTRESS
PHYSICAL PAIN AFFECTS
MOTIVATIONAL AGENCY
DISRUPTION OF DAILY
FUNCTIONS
SEEKING MEDICAL HELP
WANTING NORMALITY AND
SELF-SUFFICIENCY

Themeing the Data: Phenomenologically, later in this chapter, will illustrate how themes can be organized into various outline formats for analysis and reflection. In this section, I describe the phrasing and composition of the thematic statements mentioned earlier.

The first two categorical themes, EXPERIENCING MOBILITY-AFFECTING PAIN and ASKING FOR PRAYER AND PROVISION, include gerunds ("-ing" words) that suggest action and thus process, the core of the study's central research question, "What is the process of becoming physically disabled?" If the first two themes had been merely phrased as the nouns PAIN and PRAYER, the brevity of these one-word assignments would better function as codes or categories, not as extended thematic statements, which include richer descriptions.

Another set of categorical themes, PHYSICAL PAIN AFFECTS MOTIVATIONAL AGENCY and DEBILITATING PAIN LEADS TO

EMOTIONAL DISTRESS, also suggests process since causation is inferred through the themes' propositional structures (e.g., *X AFFECTS Y*, *X LEADS TO Y*). These themes are also composed as complete sentences, a key feature of thematic analysis. The central research question for a study to a large degree influences the types of (i.e., grammar and syntax of) thematic statements assigned to the data.

A third categorical thematic pattern is the repetition of selected thematic statements. In the previous example, *DISRUPTION OF DAILY FUNCTIONS* and *PHYSICAL PAIN AFFECTS MOTIVATIONAL AGENCY* appear not just twice but each over ten times in the total data corpus. Frequency is not always an indicator of significance, but neither is it to be dismissed if the salience or magnitude of the theme demands analytic attention.

Just as with coding, themeing also relies on analytic memoing to unpack and expand on the themes in progress as preparation for the final report. The following is an excerpt from the researcher's journal after themeing Michael's entire six-month social media data set. Notice how thematic phrases are set in caps and woven into the narrative to stay grounded in the initial analysis:

I recall reading that Kathy Charmaz called her grounded theory's core category in a comparable study "adapting." But I was struck by Michael's use of the term "commitment." His depressive nature and defeatism ("pack it all in," "giving up") is his way. He said he identified with the Disney character Eeyore. Depression is his *modus operandi*.

ASSISTANCE FROM OTHERS (doctors, physical therapists, social workers, social service agencies, friends, etc.) suggests a loss of independence from the very beginning of becoming physically disabled that increases in networks through time. *EXPRESSING NEGATIVE EMOTIONS* may be a given, but it's a core drive that may lead to defeatism, prayer, and other desperate acts. *COMMITMENT TO A NEW WAY OF LIFE* is comparable to Charmaz's "adapting," but the word *COMMITMENT* has a stronger feel to it, the "giving up" when admitting that physical limitations prevent one from accomplishing daily routines.

Using anthropology's classic cultural shock and adaptation model, Michael has *acculturated* to becoming physically disabled more than he has successfully adjusted and adapted to it. Acculturation is the "I'll live with it but I won't like it" perspective, much like Michael expresses toward the end of his social media posts.

Themeing the Data: Categorically is an appropriate method choice when the researcher feels that shorter-phrased codes may be too reductive or when shorter-phrased categories may seem too limiting as analytic outcomes. Themes allow the analyst to "breathe" through extended phrases and sentences. Codes provide detail, but themes provide nuance.

Themeing the Data: Phenomenologically

A phenomenological approach to themeing the data utilizes two prompts: what the experience *is* or *means* for the participant, as interpreted by the analyst:

- IS prompts refer to the particular, actual, or observable, such as:
 - BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED IS PAINFUL.
 - BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED IS MEDICAL DIAGNOSTICS.
- MEANS prompts refer to the general, abstract, or conceptual, such as:
 - BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED MEANS INSECURITY.
 - BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED MEANS SETBACKS.

The following is the same data set from the previous categorical themeing example, but in this method, the themes focus exclusively on the phenomenon of interest and its differently worded primary research question, “What does it mean to become physically disabled?” Thus, statements are phrased as either BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED [🔗] IS, or [🔗] MEANS (and the choice of prompts is at the researcher’s discretion):

December 11, 2019 [FRIENDS POST]

My back is a bit worse again this evening. Very difficult to sit upright. Sadly, the muscle relaxer is not fully covered by my insurance. ... Keep on praying God will provide!

[🔗] IS INCREASED PHYSICAL DIFFICULTY
 [🔗] IS A LACK OF INSURANCE
 [🔗] IS PRAYING TO A HIGHER POWER FOR HELP

December 28, 2019 [PRIVATE MESSAGE]

My arms and legs are beginning to feel like jelly. Plus, I’m getting low on the courage, will power, and determination required to get me up on my feet to use the bathroom. Just getting it off my chest. Sometimes it helps just to talk about it.

[🔗] MEANS DEFEATISM
 [🔗] IS ACKNOWLEDGING ONE’S LIMITATIONS
 [🔗] IS VENTING

December 30, 2019 [FRIENDS POST]

I think maybe I need to call soon for medical assistance. It took me half an hour and a lot of anger and cussing and tears to get up out of bed this time. I just want to lie here. ... I’m getting too shaky and lightheaded to make it to the kitchen. I have a call into the doctor about getting Home Health services, but the staff there is notoriously slow about returning calls. I just want to be able to get up and take care of myself.

[🔗] IS EXPRESSING NEGATIVE EMOTIONS
 [🔗] MEANS DEFEATISM
 [🔗] MEANS RESISTING LIMITATIONS

The phenomenological thematic analysis of the data corpus generated 47 themes. I recommend that researchers first cluster and alphabetize all IS and MEANS statements separately to scan for any detectable patterns. (Alphabetizing categorical themes first to construct patterns in progress is also a recommended heuristic.) The MEANS statements, for example, are as follows:

- ☞ MEANS A LACK OF PROGRESS
- ☞ MEANS COMMITMENT TO A NEW WAY OF LIFE
- ☞ MEANS DEFEATISM
- ☞ MEANS DEFEATISM
- ☞ MEANS “GIVING UP”
- ☞ MEANS INSECURITY
- ☞ MEANS INSECURITY
- ☞ MEANS PHYSICAL LIMITATIONS
- ☞ MEANS REJECTION
- ☞ MEANS RESISTING LIMITATIONS
- ☞ MEANS SETBACKS
- ☞ MEANS SETBACKS
- ☞ MEANS SEVERE PHYSICAL LIMITATIONS
- ☞ MEANS STALLED PROGRESS
- ☞ MEANS “TO PACK IT ALL IN”

An overall negative tone and several repetitions appear in the list: DEFEATISM (and its comparable in vivo themes “GIVING UP” and “TO PACK IT ALL IN”), INSECURITY, LIMITATIONS, and its related theme, SETBACKS. These patterns in progress alert the researcher to consider their assignment as primary themes as analysis proceeds. Like Themeing the Data: Categorically, phenomenological themes are then clustered into comparable groups as a prelude to hierarchical outlining and processual ordering, as illustrated next. Selected themes are chosen as primary headings and set in bold font:

- ☞ **IS EXTREME PAIN**
 - ☞ IS PAINFUL
- ☞ MEANS SEVERE PHYSICAL LIMITATIONS
 - ☞ MEANS PHYSICAL LIMITATIONS
 - ☞ IS INCREASED PHYSICAL DIFFICULTY
- ☞ IS ACKNOWLEDGING ONE’S LIMITATIONS
- ☞ **IS RECEIVING MEDICAL DIAGNOSTICS**
 - ☞ IS RECEIVING MEDICAL DIAGNOSTICS
 - ☞ IS MEDICAL DIAGNOSTICS
 - ☞ IS MEDICAL DIAGNOSTICS

- ☞ IS RECEIVING PHYSICAL THERAPY**
- ☞ IS RECEIVING PHYSICAL THERAPY**
- ☞ IS RECEIVING PHYSICAL THERAPY**
 - ☞ IS ASSISTANCE BY PHYSICAL THERAPISTS**

- ☞ IS A SLOW RECOVERY**
 - ☞ MEANS STALLED PROGRESS**
 - ☞ MEANS A LACK OF PROGRESS**
 - ☞ MEANS SETBACKS**
 - ☞ MEANS SETBACKS**

- ☞ MEANS INSECURITY**
- ☞ MEANS INSECURITY**
- ☞ IS A LACK OF INSURANCE**

- ☞ IS ASKING FOR ASSISTANCE FROM OTHERS**
 - ☞ IS NEEDING EMERGENCY SERVICES**
- ☞ IS ASSISTANCE BY SOCIAL SERVICES**
 - ☞ IS NEEDING SOCIAL SERVICES**
 - ☞ IS NEEDING APPROVAL**
 - ☞ MEANS REJECTION**
 - ☞ IS SEEKING HOME CARE**
 - ☞ IS MODIFYING THE HOME**
 - ☞ IS REQUESTING ADVICE**

- ☞ IS EXPRESSING NEGATIVE EMOTIONS**
 - ☞ IS FRUSTRATION**
 - ☞ IS VENTING**
- ☞ MEANS RESISTING LIMITATIONS**

- ☞ IS PRAYING TO A HIGHER POWER FOR HELP**
- ☞ IS ASKING FOR PRAYER**
- ☞ IS ASKING FOR PRAYER**
- ☞ IS ASKING FOR PRAYER**
- ☞ IS ASKING FOR PRAYER**
- ☞ IS ASKING FOR PRAYER**

- ☞ IS BIG DECISION-MAKING**
 - ☞ MEANS DEFEATISM**
 - ☞ MEANS DEFEATISM**
 - ☞ MEANS “GIVING UP”**
 - ☞ MEANS “TO PACK IT ALL IN”**

- ☞ MEANS COMMITMENT TO A NEW WAY OF LIFE**

The first-level outlined themes are then brought together for further hierarchical outlining and processual ordering, resulting in this case with three primary themes and their related subthemes. This could also serve as a preliminary outline for the analysis section of a report:

BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED IS ASKING FOR ASSISTANCE FROM OTHERS

-  IS EXTREME PAIN
-  IS RECEIVING MEDICAL DIAGNOSTICS
-  IS RECEIVING PHYSICAL THERAPY
-  IS A SLOW RECOVERY

BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED IS EXPRESSING NEGATIVE EMOTIONS

-  MEANS INSECURITY
-  IS PRAYING TO A HIGHER POWER FOR HELP

BECOMING PHYSICALLY DISABLED MEANS COMMITMENT TO A NEW WAY OF LIFE

-  IS BIG DECISION-MAKING

Timmermans and Tavory (2022) caution,

We are not in the business of compiling lists. If the takeaway of your analysis is ‘we identified three themes in the interviews ...,’ you have more work ahead. A taxonomy of topics does not constitute an argument.

(p. 114)

Just as coding is in service to thinking through analytic memoing (see researcher’s journal example earlier in this chapter), *themeing is in service to developing an analytic narrative that explicates the data’s meanings and inter-relationships*. The three bolded themes noted earlier seem like obvious “so what?” findings. But, like codes, initial themes are *prompts* for the deeper meanings they evoke. EXPRESSING NEGATIVE EMOTIONS serves as a first draft placeholder for a revised, more richly phrased analytic theme, such as EMERGENT PHYSICAL DISABILITY DISPIRITS BOTH THE VULNERABLE BODY AND EMOTIONAL RESILIENCY.

Themeing the Data: Phenomenologically is an appropriate method choice when the researcher conducts case studies, interpretative phenomenological analysis, and conceptually driven analyses for theory development. Both themeing approaches (categorically and phenomenologically), in fact, can be integrated into the same analysis. The purpose of themeing, as with all analytic methods for qualitative data, is to generate social understanding, insight, and revelation (Wolcott, 1994).

Other Thematic Analysis Structures

The scholarly literature offers multiple ways of documenting and reporting thematic analyses. In Fredricks et al.'s (2002) article, "A Qualitative Exploration of Adolescents' Commitment to Athletics and the Arts," researchers investigated the motivations behind and experiences of young people's participation in extracurricular school activities. The analysis classified thematic statements under major "factors" (i.e., categories), and the themes themselves were phrased as in vivo participant quotes, such as "Because I Am Good at It," "Because My Friends Are There," and "I Think I've Learned a Lot." Khatib et al. (2023), in "Mental Health Literacy [MHL] Among General Practitioners in Israel: A Qualitative Study," prefaced exemplar participant quotes as in vivo themes with concepts from previous research in MHL. Two examples include:

- **Theme: Recognition of mental disorders:** "It's easiest to diagnose depression, schizophrenia, and OCD."
- **Theme: Knowledge and beliefs about self-care:** "Physical, religious, and spiritual activities are not suited for alleviation of severe mental disorders" (p. 79)

A richly worded example of themes can be found in Berg et al.'s (2022) conference presentation, "Graduate Experiences: Living During the Pandemic." The research team conducted focus groups with university students in clinical psychology to understand their learning experiences during the COVID-19 pandemic. The themes demonstrate clear, detailed, and specific statements that extend beyond the categorical; a few examples include

- "a focus on school, learning and creating change as a stabilizer or refuge against uncertainty,"
- "a sense of exhaustion and weariness overtaking any fears that existed in the beginning of the pandemic," and
- "feelings of pride about the effectiveness of online learning platform, but frustrations with administration about not being transparent, staying 'ahead of the curve' and more quickly creating solutions for the diverse needs of advanced students" (n.p.)

Just some of the multiple ways researchers have documented their thematic analysis findings/outcomes in published reports include:

- Two (or more) column tables illustrating:
 - themes in one column with their extended definitions and/or exemplar participant quotes or supplemental evidence in the second column

- themes in one column with their frequencies or percentages in the second column
- how codes or categories were grouped together to develop an overarching theme
- how pattern or axial codes (sometimes labeled subthemes) were combined to create a main theme
- descriptive themes in one column with analytic/interpretive themes in the second column
- for a grounded theory study, themes as properties in one column with their ranges/dimensions in the second column
- themes as concerns, barriers, problems, etc., in one column, with advice, facilitators, proposed solutions, etc., in the second column
- themes from one group or time period compared with themes from a different group or time period, including any cross-cutting themes
- themes in one column and their formulation into a broader concept, metatheme, or theory in the second column
- For mixed-methods studies, thematic statements composed from the results of a quantitative analysis (e.g., a *t*-test)
- Brief narrative vignettes illustrating or exemplifying a theme
- Visual representations and displays:
 - bullet-pointed key themes in a box or table as policy or practice (e.g., a checklist)
 - themes in a Venn diagram illustrating their overlap and synthesis
 - themes in a model or process diagram illustrating participant actions through time
 - themes in a concept map, fishbone, force field, integration framework, or hierarchical tree diagram (metatheme, constituent themes, their subthemes, related codes, their subcodes)
 - thematic statements embedded in metaphoric diagrams (e.g., balancing scales, clocks, maps)
 - artwork illustrating or exemplifying the theme(s) (e.g., participant drawings, collages, digital photographs)

Conclusion

In addition to numerous titles in qualitative data analysis, I recommend that you access book-length works focused exclusively on thematic analysis and its methodological cousin, interpretative phenomenological analysis: Auerbach and Silverstein (2003), Braun and Clarke (2022), Guest et al. (2012), King and Brooks (2017), Smith et al. (2022), Smith and Nizza (2022), Terry and Hayfield (2021), and Thomas (2019). For an extended discussion of themeing the data, see Saldaña (2021, pp. 257–275). Also, access the

online resource thematicanalysis.net and *The Qualitative Report's* curated list of thematic analysis articles at tqr.nova.edu/thematic-analysis-articles/.

As you read the following chapters contributed by a diverse group of research methodologists, acknowledge that each writer will conceptualize, define, and represent a theme in their own signature way, just as I have. This should not be perceived as confusing inconsistency but as a wide array of options for your own reflection and analytic practice. These options strengthen qualitative inquiry by allowing each researcher to strategically select the most appropriate method(s) for their unique project's data and thematic analysis approach.

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